Indira's well-known advisers included Principal Secretary Parameshwar Narayan Haksar, Chairman, Policy Planning Committee Durga Prasad Dhar and some journalists such as G. Parthasarathy and Inder Malhotra. For advice, Indira chose people whose views aligned with hers but she was also known to be paranoid about loyalty. The slightest suspicion of disloyalty or perceived attempt to outgrow one's shoes would lead to even senior politicians or advisers being barred from even meeting with Indira. 'Indira Gandhi used men of ability almost as errand boys,' wrote Surjit Mansingh, who is known otherwise for being sympathetic to Indira Gandhi. 'When she valued their advice, trusted their discretion and had confidence in their loyalty to her person, she set them a variety of tasks, irrespective of their institutional position.'[19]

Indira's son, Rajiv, carried on his mother's tendency of accumulating power in the PMO when he stepped into office after his mother's assassination in 1984. He was not a traditional politician and was, therefore, not as interested in domestic politics. Rajiv was, however, impatient to bring about change in India and saw foreign policy as an important instrument of integrating India with the modern developed world. Faced with an entrenched bureaucracy and unsure of whom to trust in the domestic sphere, he found it easier to deal with foreign than domestic politics.

Reluctance to trust a bureaucracy that he saw as an impediment to change led Rajiv to concentrate even more authority within his office. Not only did he increase the number of foreign service officers attached to the PMO but he also sought out civil servants he could personally trust. Rajiv retained the foreign affairs portfolio for some time, like his grandfather, but ultimately appointed politicians from the Congress party as external affairs minister. Kunwar Natwar Singh, a former foreign secretary who had grown close to Indira, was appointed as minister of state for foreign affairs.